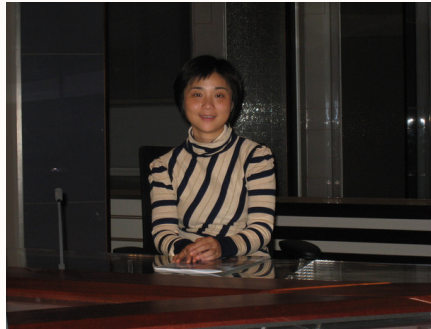


AT 28, AT THE CROSSROADS



The year Mum got her undergraduate degree



The year Mum got her first postgraduate degree in France



The year Mum got married



Grandmum, mum and I

At the age of 28, my mum reached her career milestone by moving up from a junior director to a producer. During the final rehearsal of the first programme she independently led, she rushed from the shoot to the hospital and gave birth to me. Two of the most pivotal moments happened simultaneously: as her career accelerated, she became a mother. Throughout my upbringing, she has been my rock and confidante. Mum penned nearly hundreds of letters to me, each radiating the contentment of motherhood. She also has a close-knit connection with my dad, filled with love, friendship, admiration, and appreciation. For Mum, family life is intricately intertwined with being a self-empowered woman.



The year I was born

As Bird-Pollan (2020) clarifies, individuals could have different attachment levels to socially identified identity concepts, and intersectionality expresses this flexible logic of identity. Mum was born into an enlightened family with abundant opportunities in pre-established-class China. Despite the upheavals of the Cultural Revolution, her parents pursued higher education and became teachers. This fortunate background allowed her to make choices that deviated from social norms. Her experiences exemplify how identities are reciprocally constructed, forming an interdependent system (Collins 2015). Her fortune in navigating constraints echoed Sylvia Wynter's caution to break free from white bourgeois masculinity and any specific standard of "proper person" (Mignolo 2015, 106–23).

Surprisingly, I found evidence supporting both the additive and constitutive models of intersectionality in Mum's journey. The additive model highlights that inequalities don't permanently interlock (Christoffersen and Emejulu 2022). Thus, while gender is a core disadvantaged identity, adhering to the idea of grading identity differences, her other privileges seem to overshadow gender disadvantage (Choo and Ferree 2010). For instance, living her entire life in Shanghai, a city epitomising China's economic boom (Lyons 1997), provided Mum with extensive opportunities during a social class fluctuation (Bian 2002; Davis 1995). My grandparents supported Mum's privileged higher education, a rarity for many women at the time (Attané 2012). She was recommended for admission to one of the top universities, which garnered her more recognition and opportunities in her career.



In her childhood



The year Mum got her second postgraduate degree in London

After graduating from the specialised teacher-training university, Mum rejected a school offer, sacrificing the stability of this job and its edge in the marriage market. Instead, to join a state broadcaster, she paid a hefty fine following the government's talent cultivation policy, which aims to motivate students specialising as high school teachers by providing scholarships and career security. For national security, state-owned broadcasters in late 20th-century China enjoyed monopolies and privileged treatment (Lin, Cai and Li 2003; Wang 2022). Although this is widely acknowledged, not every graduate had the chance to pursue a profession with elevated occupational status due to heavy fines and uncertainty.

Although this is widely acknowledged, not every graduate had the chance to pursue a profession with elevated occupational status due to heavy fines and uncertainty. Mum was brave and abandoned sunk costs with family support and financial viability.



She was wearing this ugly hat all the time because the abortion

Examining the constitutive model of intersectionality, it is because Mum's female identity didn't impede her growth, nor did other identities. According to her, childbirth never hindered her opportunities. Appreciation from female leaders helped her accumulate valuable experience, fortifying her against childbirth-related workplace challenges. Her specialised career in children's channels even flourished thanks to motherhood. Producing shows aligned with the age group I was growing up in, she actively understands her target audience. Her main criterion in show creation is whether she would feel comfortable if I watched them alone. This mindset contributes to her shows being outstanding.

As the mum of a girl, she aimed to raise me as a resilient woman, motivating herself to read feminist materials extensively. Mum didn't explicitly experience the global women's rights movement during her growth. But she immersed herself in the waves of feminism in my upbringing. She recalls a profound awakening when I expressed a desire to pursue graduate studies in America for three years and venture into architectural design. Initially, she was concerned about how this might affect my marriage prospects and hesitant about a "girl like me" enduring the rigours of architecture. Through our arguments, she realised, "I'm raising my daughter, not cultivating a wife."



We are used to convey our affection through writing. Mum writes on red envols on Chinese New Year

I view Mum's journey as an ongoing combat with gender disadvantages by leveraging other advantages. My frequent illnesses led her to blame herself for miscarriages during working pregnancy and deviating from traditional breastfeeding practices due to her eagerness to return to work. Her emotional burden reflects the influence of Confucian ideals and conventional beliefs about pregnancy restrictions (Lau 2012). However, growing up in an environment without assuming women share uniform identities, interests, and goals minimises regulation and reification (Butler 1990). Her absence from caregiving fueled her guilt. Seeking the best educational resources for me is her compensation. She is allowed to play the role of a mum on her own terms. When Mum got the opportunity to pursue her first graduate degree in France, she was unexpectedly pregnant. Again, she resolutely chose abortion to prioritise self-realisation. In fact, Mum's constant discomfort with societal expectations validates the tension between multiple identity relations, as Crenshaw and Collins noted in their 1980s definition of intersectionality (Bird-Pollan 2020).



We're always travelling on Mum's holidays